INT. ART STUDIO - AFTERNOON

A narrow beam of sunlight pours through a large skylight. Dust floats slowly in the air.

In an old studio, walls covered with portraits featuring different faces. They all have the same unsettling expression—calm, exposed.

ALEX (38) sits at an easel. A nearly finished portrait of a man rests on the canvas except the eyes have been scraped away.

Alex flips the canvas. Begins painting on the back. He checks his watch: 2:26 PM. His brushstrokes suddenly grow faster with more aggressive movements.

Three firm knocks appears. Alex doesn't turn.

ALEX
The door is open.

The door opens. MR. CHEN (50) enters. He is well-dressed and controlled. He scans the room.

MR. CHEN
Good afternoon Mr. Alex. I've heard a lot about you.

ALEX
You're twenty minutes early.

MR. CHEN
Traffic was light. Thought we could talk about the painting.

ALEX
Nothing to talk about. You sit. I paint.

MR. CHEN
I paid a deposit. I think I should know how you plan to paint me.

Alex turns, studies him.

ALEX
How do you want to be seen?

MR. CHEN
Composed. Respected. Not intimidating.
(MORE)

MR. CHEN (CONT'D)
Simple background.

ALEX
Alright. Sit.

Mr. Chen sits on the chair. Alex flips the canvas, revealing the earlier portrait. The empty eye sockets.

MR. CHEN
You already painted me?

ALEX
That was before. I erased it.

Alex replaces it with a blank canvas. He starts sketching. The room is silent.

MR. CHEN
Are these portraits all your clients?

ALEX
Most of them.

MR. CHEN
They all look… similar.

ALEX
Like something’s been taken off?

Mr. Chen doesn’t respond.

ALEX (CONT'D)
I don’t paint faces. I paint what people hide.

MR. CHEN
And what do you see in me?

Alex keeps drawing. No answer.

INT. ART STUDIO - LATER

The sketch is forming. Mr. Chen shifts in his seat.

MR. CHEN
How long does this usually take?

ALEX
It depends on the person.

MR. CHEN
Am I easy to paint?

Alex pauses. Looks directly at him.

ALEX
You’re layered. I have to peel.

Mr. Chen stiffens.

MR. CHEN
I know you painted Mr. Zhou before. He liked it.

ALEX
His wife didn’t.

MR. CHEN
Why?

ALEX
She saw the version of him he hides at home.

Silence. Mr. Chen’s fingers tap the chair. Suddenly, Alex drops his brush.

ALEX (CONT'D)
That’s enough for today.

MR. CHEN
We’re not done.

ALEX
You’re not ready.

Mr. Chen stands, trying to control his anger.

MR. CHEN
I need this next week. This isn’t therapy.

ALEX
Then find someone else to paint your mask.

A long pause. Mr. Chen exhales. He studies Alex. Then, he laughs. Quiet, real. He sits back down.

MR. CHEN
…Continue, please.

Alex watches him. Then resumes painting.

TIME CUT - LATER

The portrait is nearly complete. This version of Mr. Chen is different. It is softer, tired, more human.

MR. CHEN
Can I see it?

Alex blocks him.

ALEX
Not yet.

ALEX (CONT'D)
You'll hang this at your company?

MR. CHEN
Yes.

ALEX
What do you want them to see?

Silence. Mr. Chen doesn't answer.

ALEX (CONT'D)
I can give you authority. That's easy.
Or… this.

He gestures to the painting.

ALEX (CONT'D)
But this one… is your choice.

Long pause. Mr. Chen walks to the door. Then, he stops.

MR. CHEN
Finish it. The way you see it.

He doesn't turn back to Alex.

MR. CHEN (O.S.)
Has anyone ever painted you?

Alex doesn't answer. The door closes.

INT. STUDIO - CONTINUOUS

Alex sits still. He walks to a dusty corner. Pulls out a small canvas, and turns it over.

It is a self-portrait. A younger Alex looking lost and uncertain.

He stares at it. Then flips it face down again.

INT. STUDIO - NEXT DAY

A soft knock sound appears while Alex is working on Mr.Chen's portrait.

Amanda (30s) enters. She looks sharp and observant.

AMANDA
Working again?

ALEX
Yes.

She approaches the painting.

AMANDA
This doesn’t look like him.

ALEX
What does it look like?

AMANDA
Like him ten years ago.

Alex glances at her.

AMANDA (CONT'D)
You’re still not joining the exhibition?

ALEX
I don't have time.

AMANDA
You always say that.

Amanda smiles.

AMANDA (CONT'D)
Forget it, I won’t push you. But there’s one thing. There’s a little girl who wants you to teach her painting. Her mother asked me to ask you.

ALEX
I don’t take students.

AMANDA
I know. But she’s special. You’ll see.

She takes a sheet of paper out of the folder and places it on the coffee table. It’s a child’s drawing: a crooked house, a sun, and a small figure.

AMANDA (CONT'D)
Her name is Maddy. She’s seven. Her mother said she draws every day, and then tears them up when she’s done. She never keeps anything. She says, “Once it’s finished, there’s no need to keep it.”

Alex stops painting. He looks at the drawing for a long time. The rigid expression on his face wavered.

ALEX
How old is she?

AMANDA
Seven.

ALEX
Let her come. Saturday afternoon.

Amanda smiles again. She looks at the portrait.

AMANDA
Mr. Chen will hate this painting.

ALEX
That’s not my problem.

She shook her head slightly and then walks away.

INT. STUDIO - EVENING

The painting is finished. Mr. Chen sits in the portrait—unguarded, real.

Alex signs it. He steps back. His eyes stare at the portrait.

Silence.

He walks to the window. The city glows in sunset. Children’s laughter outside.

ALEX (V.O.)
I’ve spent my life painting others. They come in with masks… leave wearing them again. Sometimes I wonder if I sat here, what would I look like on canvas?

He turns back. The portrait seems to look at him.

INT. ART STUDIO - LATER

ALEX
Would you hang it?

No answer. He turns off the light and leaves the studio.

Darkness. Only the faint outline of the painting remains.

FADE OUT.

BLACK SCREEN

TEXT ON SCREEN:
“Every portrait is a self-portrait.”